

CHAPTER 32 — The Reaction

Wednesday morning began with three envelopes.

None contained letters.

Zoe had bought them from a corner shop because the hotel reception only had white ones with the hotel name printed across the back.

Branding, Elias had said, was unnecessary evidence.

Zoe had told him that was the least exciting reason anyone had ever rejected stationery.

Now the three plain envelopes lay across the desk.

DOCUMENT

MONEY

LEGAL

Elias stood beside the window drinking coffee.

Zoe looked at his cup.

Then at the kettle.

Then back at him.

"You made one."

"You were asleep."

"That is not a defence."

"There's tea."

"That is not coffee."

"You're thirteen."

"That is discrimination."

"It is biology."

She stared at him.

"Terrible argument."

He drank the coffee.

Which somehow made it worse.

Zoe poured tea.

The hotel room overlooked the back of a supermarket, three recycling bins and a section of brick wall on which someone had spray-painted half a word and apparently lost interest.

Nothing worth remembering.

Useful.

She sat at the desk.

The plan was already written in her notebook from the night before.

Three fragments.

Three different routes.

Nothing about children.

Nothing about current homes.

Nobody receiving enough to see the whole shape.

She tapped the envelopes.

"Still happy?"

"No."

She looked up.

Elias pulled out the chair opposite.

"I think it's controlled enough to try."

"That is not the same thing."

"No."

“Good.”

She opened the notebook.

At the top of the page:

Watch what changes.

The rest could happen without another speech.

* * *

The document question went first.

Zoe used Meridian’s public records form.

Nothing dramatic.

Nothing accusing anybody of anything.

She asked whether an old category of certification records could still be checked.

Then she waited.

Four minutes later, the answer arrived.

Archived metadata was available on request.

Please provide the relevant certification reference.

Zoe stared at it.

“That’s it?” Elias leaned over. “That’s it.” “No warning?” “No.” “No sudden compliance department?” “No.” “No mysterious men carrying boxes?” “Give them time.” She looked at him. “Was that a joke?” “No.” “It sounded like one.” “Unfortunate.” She wrote:

DOCUMENT — NORMAL ANSWER.

Then added:

No visible reaction.

She sat back. “Boring.” “Very.” “I hate it.”

“Good.”

Zoe frowned.

Elias pointed at the screen.

“If everything reacts, the test tells you nothing.”

She knew that.

Still.

It was irritating when boring things were useful.

She folded the first envelope and pushed it aside.

One down.

* * *

Voss received the money question at nine twelve.

One old accounting reference.

One question.

Was the historic settlement treated as client money or service revenue?

Nothing else.

Vale received a different message.

An old legal-verification reference and one word:

Issuer?

They were sitting at opposite ends of a rented lock-up office when both phones went.

Vale read hers.

Then looked across the room.

“What did you get?”

Voss placed his phone face down. “Different question.”

“I know it’s a different question.”

"Then you know enough."

She stared at him. "We are literally in the same room."

"Yes."

"That feels stupid."

"Probably."

"Can I know the category?"

"No."

She leaned back. "You're enjoying this."

"No."

"You are internally."

Voss ignored her. Vale looked at her phone again. Fine. Zoe wanted separate reactions. Separate meant separate. Annoying did not make it wrong.

She opened her laptop.

"Do we at least tell each other if something weird happens?"

"Yes."

"What kind of weird?"

"You'll know."

"That is extremely unhelpful."

"It is also accurate."

Vale muttered something under her breath.

Voss decided not to ask.

* * *

At nine forty-seven, he called the accounting company.

It still existed, though the name had changed.

Same registration number.

Same office.

Different people answering the phones.

Historic accounts transferred him twice before a clerk finally found the reference.

"Private administration," the clerk said.

"Yes."

"What information do you need?"

"Classification only. Client money or service revenue?"

A keyboard rattled.

"Service revenue." Voss wrote it down. Normal. "Thank you." "One moment." He waited. The typing stopped. The silence lasted long enough to become noticeable. Then: "Can I ask where you obtained that reference?" Voss looked at the clock. "Old contractor records." "What company?" "No longer active." "Do you still retain documents connected

to the account?" Across the room, Vale saw something change in his face. Not much. Enough. Voss picked up a pen.

ASKING ABOUT RETAINED RECORDS.

He turned the paper towards her. Vale raised an eyebrow.

"No," Voss said into the phone.

"Invoices?"

"No."

"Electronic scans?"

"No."

"Emails?"

"No."

Another pause.

Then the clerk's voice returned to the pleasant tone it had started with.

"Then there's nothing further required."

The call ended.

Voss looked at the handset.

Vale waited.

"That normal?"

"First half."

"And second?"

"Maybe."

"That means no."

"It means maybe."

She sighed.

"You and Elias should start a club."

Voss wrote down the times.

Answer.

Change in questioning.

Request about retained material.

Then stopped.

Nothing else had happened.

Yet.

* * *

Vale did not telephone anyone.

She emailed the legal-administration address attached to the old

verification system.

The company had changed names twice since the paperwork was issued.

The mailbox remained.

Her message was deliberately dull.

An old verification reference.

Could they confirm whether it had originally been issued by a court, Meridian or an external administrator?

No accusation.

No explanation.

Just a question someone tidying old records might reasonably ask.

Five minutes passed.

Ten.

At ten oh six, delivery confirmed.

At ten eleven, read.

Vale watched the screen.

Nothing.

She checked the company website.

The old public verification page was still there.

She looked away.

Checked again three minutes later.

Gone.

Vale stopped moving.

She did not refresh repeatedly.

She took one screenshot.

Then checked from a separate browser.

Same result.

Gone.

At ten seventeen, the page returned.

The old verification form had disappeared.

In its place:

SERVICE TEMPORARILY UNAVAILABLE. CONTACT COMPLIANCE.

Vale smiled.

Not because it was funny.

Because something had moved.

Four minutes later, an old contractor phone on the desk vibrated.

Neither she nor Voss had used it all morning.

A system message appeared.

**LEGAL VERIFICATION ROUTES UNDER
MAINTENANCE. DO NOT USE LEGACY TOKENS.**

Vale checked the time.

Ten minutes after her email had been opened.

She looked at Voss.

"Mine moved."

He looked up.

"How?"

"Not your fragment."

She smiled when she said it.

Voss looked annoyed.

That improved her morning considerably.

* * *

Mac was in a clinic car park when his solicitor called.

He had been sitting in the car longer than he intended.

People crossed the wet pavement beneath umbrellas.

A man helped an elderly woman out of a taxi.

A nurse smoked beneath a sign instructing people not to smoke.

Ordinary things.

Mac wanted ordinary things.

The solicitor said, "Two restricted references have surfaced."

Mac looked through the windscreen.

"Together?"

"No."

"Same source?"

"Unknown."

"Same case?"

"No."

"Then why are you calling?"

A pause.

"Because they arrived within forty minutes of each other."

Mac's hand tightened around the phone.

"What kind?"

"Financial. Legal."

"Which financial?"

"K08."

Not his.

Some of the pressure left his shoulders.

Then the solicitor said, "The legal reference touches an older verification structure shared with other sponsor routes."

The pressure returned.

"Shared how?"

"Document control."

"That doesn't make them connected."

"No."

"Then don't connect them." The solicitor said nothing.

Mac heard the irritation in his own voice. K08 was not his account. Therefore he wanted K08 to be somebody else's problem. The system did not care what he wanted. "What's been done?"

"Accounting was alerted."

"Anything else?"

"Legal administration changed the public verification route."

Mac looked up. "They what?"

"Temporarily removed it."

"Why?"

"They considered the reference sensitive."

"Which means they confirmed it was sensitive."

The solicitor did not answer. Mac closed his eyes. "Tell them to stop reacting."

"I don't control them."

“Then find whoever does.”

He ended the call.

The clinic remained twenty metres away.

Mac never went inside.

Instead he called a number he had not used in five years.

* * *

At ten forty-three, Voss’s old contractor portal changed.

He still had access because nobody had bothered to close the account when the company stopped using him.

Normally it contained the digital equivalent of dust.

Expired certificates.

Old invoices.

Jobs nobody cared about anymore.

Now there was a new line.

RECONCILIATION RETAINER — PENDING

Amount:

£2,400

Voss stared at it.

Vale noticed immediately.

“What?”

He turned the laptop enough for her to see the amount.

Her expression changed. “Did you ask for money?” “No.” “Did they offer you work?” “No.” “Then why do you have two thousand four hundred pounds?” “I don’t.” “You know what I mean.” Three minutes later, the

status changed.

AVAILABLE ON ACCEPTANCE

Vale came around the desk. Voss held up a hand. "Don't touch anything." "I wasn't going to." "You were leaning." "I'm allowed to lean." A new message appeared beneath the payment.

HISTORIC FILE RECONCILIATION.

Then another line.

CONFIRM DESTRUCTION OF RETAINED COPIES.

Vale stopped leaning. "That's not subtle."

"No." "They want you to say you destroyed the files." "Yes." "And then they give you money." "That is what the screen says." "Bribe." "Possibly." She looked at him. "Voss." "We record what happened." "For God's sake." "Do we accept it?" "No." "Reply?" "No." "Download anything?" "No." "Photograph?" "Yes." Vale used a separate camera. Amount. Time.

Message. Condition. They closed the portal without answering. At ten fifty-one, Voss logged back in. The payment was gone. Vale checked the camera. "Six minutes."

Voss nodded. "Long enough to be seen."

"And short enough for someone to claim it was a mistake."

"Possibly."

She pointed at him. "Do not say possibly again for at least five minutes."

"I can't promise that."

"You're becoming unbearable."

"I've been told."

* * *

Zoe received the summary at eleven oh three. The ordinary accounting answer came first. Service revenue. Then the questions about retained files.

Then, fifty-three minutes later, the dormant portal had offered Voss £2,400 for historic reconciliation if he confirmed that old copies had been destroyed.

Six minutes later, the offer vanished.

Zoe went back over the wording.

"They tried to buy his files."

Elias looked over.

"Read the wording."

"I did."

"What did it actually say?"

"Historic file reconciliation."

"And?"

"Confirm destruction of retained copies."

"And?"

"Then he gets £2,400."

Elias waited.

Zoe glared at him.

"That is buying destruction."

"Probably."

She opened her mouth.

He added, "Write what happened first."

Zoe looked at the notebook.

Fine.

She wrote:

Old accounting question.

Later: dormant contractor offered £2,400.

Payment required confirmation that retained copies had been destroyed.

Offer vanished when ignored.

Then below it:

Looks like they were worried about old records.

She read it.

Less exciting.

More solid.

“Happy?”

“Yes.”

“Of course you are.”

The legal summary arrived.

Vale’s email had been opened.

Three minutes later, the public verification page disappeared.

Three minutes after that, it returned with a compliance-only message.

Four minutes later, old contractor channels were warned not to use the legacy verification system.

Zoe looked at the three envelopes.

Document.

Nothing.

Money.

£2,400.

Legal.

The door slammed shut.

She pushed the DOCUMENT envelope slightly away from the others.

"That's useful."

Elias nodded.

She narrowed her eyes.

"You're doing it again."

"What?"

"Making me say the conclusion so you don't have to."

"I thought you preferred that."

She considered.

"I do."

The document question had behaved like a document question.

No panic.

No disappearing pages.

No sudden interest in old files.

The other two had not.

That mattered.

But it still did not prove the two reactions were connected to each other.

Not yet.

Zoe looked at the clock.

"So now?"

"We wait."

She groaned.

Waiting remained the worst investigative technique ever invented.

* * *

At eleven thirty-six, Voss received a message through a system he had not touched all day.

An old vehicle-supplier portal.

CONFIRM NO HISTORIC STORAGE AT UNIT 4B.

He stared at it.

Vale noticed.

"Yours?"

"Not really."

"What does that mean?"

"I didn't contact this channel."

Unit 4B had once been used as overflow storage.

Paper files.

Contract copies.

Job sheets. Nothing glamorous. Nothing he had mentioned to the accountant. The morning question had been about money. Now someone wanted to know whether old records still existed. Voss did not answer. Six minutes later, a vehicle booking appeared. White Transit. Two-hour collection window. Pickup from a records-storage site outside Slough. No visible destination. Vale was standing before he finished reading. "Can we go?"

"We can observe."

"That is what I meant."

"Public place."

"I know."

"No contact."

"I know."

“No following anyone onto private property.”

“I know.”

“No improvising.”

Vale picked up her coat.

“You take all the joy out of everything.”

* * *

Zoe did not go with them.

At first, that annoyed her.

Then Elias explained why.

Voss and Vale already knew the place.

They knew who they might recognise.

They could watch from somewhere public.

Zoe added nothing except another person who could be seen, followed or identified.

She considered it.

“What if they miss something?”

“Then they miss it.”

“What if I would notice something they don’t?”

“Possible.”

“So—”

“What do you add that justifies the additional risk?”

Zoe stopped.

That was more irritating because she had no good answer.

She looked at the backpack.

Then back at him.

"Fine."

Elias waited. "I said fine."

"I heard you."

"You look pleased."

"I don't."

"You do internally."

"That seems difficult to prove."

Zoe stared at him. "You stole that from me."

"No."

"You absolutely did."

They left the hotel anyway. Different town. Different room later. No reason to remain where the morning queries had started. On the bus, Zoe opened the book with the offended dragon. Three pages later she opened the notebook. Elias noticed. "You can stop working."

"I know."

"You haven't."

"I'm curious."

"That isn't always helpful."

She looked at him.

"You sound about ninety."

"I feel about ninety."

"You don't look ninety."

"Thank you."

"That wasn't a compliment."

He went back to the window.

Zoe closed the notebook.

The dragon had apparently discovered taxation.

Its mood had not improved.

Understandable.

* * *

The records-storage building outside Slough looked exactly like somewhere nobody would remember.

Grey cladding.

Security fencing.

Roller doors.

A sign containing the words DOCUMENT SOLUTIONS in a font designed to discourage curiosity.

Voss parked two streets away.

A café window gave them a partial view of the gate.

They bought drinks. Vale disliked coffee. Voss ordered her one anyway. She drank it out of spite. At twelve fifty-three, the white Transit arrived. No company markings. Three people inside. One man used a key card at the gate. It opened. The van disappeared. Vale checked the time. "Could still be normal."

"Yes."

She looked at Voss. "I said it before you did."

At one oh six, a black saloon arrived. Vale watched the driver get out. Something bothered her. Not recognition exactly. The shape of recognition. She searched old photographs on her phone. Contractor induction.

People standing beneath fluorescent lights wearing visitor badges and expressions suggesting nobody had wanted the photograph taken.

She found him.

Younger.

Less grey.

Same man.

She slid the phone towards Voss.

“Meridian.”

He compared the old image with the man crossing the pavement.

“Compliance.”

They wrote it down.

No photograph.

No approach.

At one seventeen, another car stopped outside.

Different company.

A passenger crossed towards the gate.

His company pass swung free of his jacket.

Voss recognised the logo.

Legal administration.

Vale watched him enter.

For a few seconds neither spoke.

The money question had started with an accountant.

The legal question had started with an email.

Now Meridian compliance and a legal administrator were standing inside the same records site.

Vale looked through the café glass.

“Well.”

Voss kept watching.

“That’s better.”

“Better?”

“For Zoe.”

Vale smiled faintly.

“Yes.”

At one thirty-four, the first archive box appeared.

A man carried it from the building to the Transit.

Then another.

Three went into the black saloon.

Two remained near the doorway before being taken back inside.

Seven visible.

Vale’s coffee sat untouched now.

“They’re moving them.”

“Yes.”

“Splitting them.”

“Appears so.”

“Why?”

Voss watched one of the men close the Transit door.

“Don’t know.”

“Destruction?”

“Could be.”

“Moving them somewhere safer?”

“Could be.”

“Dividing risk?”

“Could be.”

Vale looked at him.

“You’ve reached your possibly quota, so now you’ve switched words.”

Voss almost smiled.

Almost.

At one forty-one, the Meridian compliance man stepped outside.

He made a phone call.

Two minutes later, Voss’s old contractor portal produced another message.

DO NOT RETAIN HISTORIC MERIDIAN

CERTIFICATION MATERIAL.

Vale looked from the phone screen to the man outside the storage facility.

“That’s him.”

“Likely.”

She turned.

“You said likely without being corrected.”

“Growth.”

Now she did smile.

Then the Meridian man went back inside.

The smile disappeared with him.

* * *

Mac called Cain at one fifty-eight.

"You ordered the Slough archive moved?"

"No."

"Someone did."

"I know."

"Who?"

"Legal."

Mac stopped walking.

He had been pacing the corridor outside his study without noticing.

"Why would legal move a records archive because somebody asked an accounting question?"

"It wasn't only accounting."

"I know that."

"The verification reference hit a shared control structure."

Mac opened the study door.

Then closed it again without entering.

"How shared?"

"Enough."

"That isn't an answer."

"It is the answer you have."

Mac pressed his thumb against his forehead. "Has anyone identified the source?"

"No."

"Voss?"

"Possible."

"Vale?"

"Possible."

"Elias?"

"Nothing."

"Zoe?"

Cain went quiet. Mac felt the silence immediately. "What?"

"An old household check was triggered."

Mac stopped moving completely. "Which one?"

Cain gave him the number.

P06-11803.

Mac lowered the phone.

For a moment it was not a number.

It was Helen.

Brian.

Zoe.

His own mistake stretching backwards through years he had once believed were settled.

"How?"

"Legacy risk chain."

"Nobody mentioned that household."

"No."

"Then why did it touch it?"

"Because the systems share history."

Mac looked at the closed study door.

The accounting reference had belonged to someone else.

The legal reference had belonged to an older verification family.

Neither had named Zoe.

Neither had named him.

Yet somewhere inside the machinery, one alarm had touched another, and the trail had found its way back to her house.

“Stop it.”

“You can stop the next action.”

“Then do that.”

“You can’t remove the fact it happened.”

Mac ended the call.

He stood in the corridor with the phone still against his ear.

The system had been built so that nobody needed to know everything.

That was supposed to make it safe.

Now the same hidden connections were telling on themselves.

* * *

At two fourteen, Elias received Voss’s report.

He read it once.

Then handed the phone to Zoe.

She read:

The storage site activated shortly before one.

White Transit.

Meridian compliance present.

Legal-administration personnel present.

Seven archive boxes visibly moved.

Contractor warning issued during the same period.

No contact made.

No restricted premises entered.

Zoe reached the end and immediately started again.

"Meridian went there."

"Yes."

"And legal."

"Yes."

"After the money and legal questions."

"Yes."

She stopped.

Then looked at him.

"Could be coincidence."

"It could."

"Scheduled archive work."

"Possible."

"Meridian compliance just happened to be there."

"Possible."

"And legal administrators."

"Possible."

"And Voss's old portal just happened to warn him about Meridian files while they were there."

"Less comfortable."

She smiled.

“Less comfortable?”

“For coincidence.”

Zoe opened the notebook.

She did not draw a complicated map.

She wrote one sentence.

Two separate questions were followed by people from separate parts of the system arriving at the same records site.

Then:

Old records moved.

Then:

Could still have another explanation. Timing matters.

She looked at it.

She left it there.

The first test had shown a document could be false.

This one had shown something different.

You could learn about the shape of a machine by frightening it.

Not by asking who knew whom.

By watching who moved.

* * *

The last thing Zoe found that afternoon was not new.

That mattered.

The drive was still offline.

No magic updates.

No live connection to Meridian.

What she had was history.

She went back through old archived events looking for similar reactions.

Not the same references.

The same shape.

Several restricted systems suddenly becoming active within a short period.

It was rare.

But it had happened before.

And when it did, another type of check sometimes followed.

HOUSEHOLD STABILITY CONFIRMATION

Zoe stopped on the phrase.

Elias pulled his chair closer.

"What does that mean?"

"I was going to ask you."

"I haven't seen it before."

"Good."

He glanced at her.

"Why is that good?"

"Because sometimes you know everything and it's annoying."

"I don't know everything."

"Exactly. Good day."

She searched only the event history.

No household details.

No children.

Just when the checks happened.

One old sequence had followed an external enquiry. Another after a legal challenge. Another after an internal document discrepancy. Then she found the sequence she already knew. The government query. The one that came shortly before her RECOVER status. After it:

HOUSEHOLD STABILITY CONFIRMATION

Zoe felt something tighten inside her. She opened only the linked household identifier.

P06-11803

Her hand stopped on the trackpad. Elias did not move. She knew the number. Not from childhood. From the archive. Receiving household. Her receiving household. Helen and Brian. The supermarket wall outside the window disappeared. For a second she saw home instead. The narrow hall.

The coat hooks.

Brian leaving his shoes where Helen had told him not to leave them approximately nine thousand times.

The kitchen.

Helen's mug.

The radiator.

Zoe's schoolbag on the floor.

She looked back at the code.

A household stability check had followed the enquiry that eventually triggered her recovery.

Nobody spoke for a while.

Then Zoe said, "They checked them."

"Looks like it."

"Why?"

"Tomorrow."

She looked at him.

"That means you don't know."

"It means the answer is probably inside their record."

Zoe sat back.

She hated that he was right.

She also hated the next question.

What did stability mean to the people who had created the system?

Still married?

Still at the same address?

No police?

No court trouble?

No school asking questions?

Still cooperating?

Still keeping quiet?

The recipient profile returned to her.

Attachment.

A family working well made the beginning harder to disturb.

Zoe shut the search.

"Not yet."

Elias nodded.

No congratulations.

No suggestion that she had discovered something enormous.

Just room.

She needed that more.

* * *

That evening they ate in the supermarket café because Zoe wanted chips and Elias had reached the stage of his life where arguing about chips was beneath him.

The backpack sat between her feet.

Families moved through the checkout lanes beyond the glass.

A little boy was having what appeared to be a constitutional crisis over breakfast cereal.

His mother remained unimpressed.

A man carried a sleeping girl against his shoulder while steering a trolley one-handed.

An elderly couple argued about whether they needed washing powder.

Ordinary people.

Ordinary homes.

Zoe stabbed a chip with her fork.

"What would you check?"

Elias looked at her.

"In what?"

"A household stability thing."

"We agreed tomorrow."

"I'm not asking what Helen and Brian's file says."

"What are you asking?"

"What would you check?"

He considered.

"Whether the household still existed."

"Meaning?"

"Same people. Same address."

"Still together."

"Yes."

"Police?"

"Possibly."

"Court?"

"Possibly."

"School problems?"

"Possibly."

She pointed the chip at him. "That one is yours now."

"What?"

"Possibly."

"I see."

"You've ruined it."

Elias ate another chip. Zoe watched the people beyond the glass.
"Whether they'd still cooperate."

"That would matter."

"Whether they could be contacted."

"Yes."

She hesitated. "And whether the child still wanted to stay."

Elias looked at her.

Zoe put the chip down.

Because there it was again.

The thing she had understood beside the canal.

Love.

Not fake.

Not meaningless.

Useful.

If a child loved the people raising them, the cost of exposing the beginning became higher.

If the adults loved the child, they had more to lose too.

The system did not need to threaten anybody with a gun.

Sometimes it only needed to remind them what truth could destroy.

Zoe looked down at her plate.

Then another memory arrived.

Helen in the hallway.

Phone to her ear.

Voice low.

A call she had pretended was a wrong number.

Zoe remembered enough of the words now.

No, she hasn't said anything.

Yes, I'll keep an eye out.

She had heard them before everything collapsed.

Before the van. Before the airport. Before Elias. Zoe felt her stomach turn. "Helen's phone call."

Elias watched her. "The one before I was taken."

"Yes."

"What if that was something like this?"

"Could fit."

"Mac checking the house."

"Could fit."

"Asking if I'd noticed anything."

"Could fit."

"She said I hadn't said anything."

"Yes."

Zoe stared at the table. "And she'd keep an eye out."

"Yes."

The memory fitted too well. That was dangerous. Zoe knew that now.

A piece that fitted was not automatically the right piece.

She picked up another chip.

"Not proof."

"No."

"Good."

Elias looked at her.

She shrugged.

"I don't like it. But it's good."

Tomorrow she could open the adult side of the household record.

Not the photographs.

Not whatever Helen had said in private interviews.

Not every medical detail or every piece of grief somebody had turned into data.

She needed less than that.

What they knew.

What they agreed to.

What they paid.

What they did.

That was enough.

Possibly.

She frowned at Elias.

"This is your fault."

"What is?"

"Nothing."

* * *

Mac spent the evening discovering that everybody had a solution.

Accounting wanted dormant credentials closed.

Legal wanted old verification routes removed.

Meridian wanted historic certification material recalled.

Cain wanted sponsor channels watched.

Somebody else wanted the storage archive divided again.

Every part of the system was attempting to make itself safer.

Every attempt caused more movement.

More calls.

More messages.

More records.

Mac approved almost nothing.

Then another call came.

A senior voice.

"The household check completed."

Mac did not ask which household.

He already knew.

"Still occupied?"

"Yes."

"Helen and Brian?"

"Yes."

"Any contact?"

"No recent sponsor contact."

Mac stared through the study window.

The garden was dark.

For years, P06-11803 had been quiet.

That had been its value.

Nothing happened there.

Nothing drew attention.

Nothing needed fixing.

Now the system had looked at it again because questions had been asked somewhere else.

"Do not contact them."

The voice paused.

"Why?"

Mac looked at his reflection in the glass.

Because every time they moved, somebody might be watching.

Because the person asking questions had learned that fear travelled faster than information.

Because the network had spent years surviving through compartments, and now the compartments were announcing themselves by rushing towards the same fire.

“Because nothing else moves tonight.”

Silence.

Then:

“Understood.”

The call ended.

Mac remained at the window.

For once, doing nothing did not feel like control.

It felt like being afraid to touch anything.

* * *

Zoe lay awake longer than she wanted.

Not because she thought someone was outside.

Not because she expected the door to open.

Because of a number.

P06-11803

The backpack sat against the wall.

Elias was in the other bed.

Possibly asleep.

With Elias, sleep and lying perfectly still while listening to everything were annoyingly difficult to distinguish.

Zoe turned onto her side.

Helen.

Brian.

Packed lunches.

Brian pretending he had fixed things that would break again three days later.

Helen putting fruit beside her cereal because apparently thirteen-year-olds could not be trusted to locate vitamins independently.

The stupid mug.

The stupid crack above the stairs.

Home.

None of that had become false.

That was why what came next felt worse.

If Helen and Brian had never loved her, the answer would be easier.

If they had simply been cruel people pretending to be parents, Zoe already knew what to do with cruel people.

But they had loved her.

She knew that.

She did not need a database to tell her.

The next question was about something else.

What had they chosen before that love became birthdays and school uniforms and arguments about homework?

What had they known before she became their daughter?

Zoe stared into the dark.

Today she had touched three parts of the machine.

One had answered normally.

Two had become nervous.

Then money moved.

Messages changed.

People crossed organisational lines.

Boxes left a building.

And without anybody mentioning Zoe at all, the fear had travelled backwards until it reached her house.

Tomorrow she would find out why.

Not whether Helen and Brian loved her.

She already knew they did.

She was going to find out what they had agreed to before they ever had the chance.